

15.3MP Sigma SD1

Sigma launches 15.3 MP CMOS sensor camera which lacks video shooting capability

Panasonic Lumix GH2

Panasonic Lumix GH2 features 16 MP, LiveMOS sensor, 3-inch LCD, 3D interchangeable lens and also 1080p video recording

Touchscreen

Touchscreen phones are flooding the cell phone market like never before. Thanks to the rise of smartphones, the importance of touchscreens has amplified. Samsung Corby series broke the glass ceiling of ₹10,000 with its affordable touchscreen phones paving the way for more handset manufacturers to come out with their version of affordable touchscreen phones. LG's Cookie series also have a range of touchscreen options. However, do not confuse these phones with smartphones as they are not. These phones are feature-rich phones. It's safe to say that you should opt for capacitive touchscreens over resistive ones. Resistive touch response will deteriorate over time and reach a point where you will actually have to press the phone screen hard to register a response. If the phone requires the use of a stylus, we would recommend that you avoid it altogether.

HTC and Apple phones have amazing touch response. It is high time Nokia also switched to this technology as we really don't know how it expects to compete on user experience with resistive touch screen phones. As of date, Nokia just has the X6 with a 3.2 inch capacitive touch screen.

A lot of the entry-level phones also come with touchscreens, but the experience leaves a lot to be desired.

Those of you who are used to a QWERTY keypad, be careful before opting for a touchscreen phone without a keypad. Expect your typing speeds to take a hit. Look for slide out keypads instead. The Motorola Milestone is a good

phone in that respect, so is Sony Ericsson Xperia X10 Mini Pro.

Processor

These days, you've started expecting your phone to do things that only your PC used to. Thus the importance of the processor performance increases. For a high-end

smartphone the processor should have a minimum of 800MHz rating – 1 GHz is ideal. This also makes your handset future proof.

Display technologies

Phone displays also add a dimension to the overall user experience. Off late, AMOLED and Super AMOLED displays seen in Samsung phones are the talk of the town. Samsung Wave sports a Super AMOLED screen which really enhances the quality of the display. Since AMOLED technology does not use backlighting, the blacks are jet black, thus giving more vivid images and better contrast than standard LCD technology. HTC which had the AMOLED screen in some of its handsets (HTC Desire for instance) will soon switch to Sony's Super LCD (SLCD) display technology due to shortage of AMOLED screens from Samsung (which is understandable considering Samsung will give first priority to its handsets). Comparing these two technologies, it is not easy to pick a winner. AMOLED has a headstart with many phones using this technology available in India. SLCD is yet to make an entry here.

As of now, the phones sporting AMOLED and Super AMOLED technology are expensive. For sub-₹15,000 phones you will still have to stick with LCD technology. The newer display technologies are ideal if you consume a lot of multimedia on your phone and want the best visual experience possible.

BUSTING MYTHS

Marketers are known to use a lot of jargon to sell their products. So let us try to see just how important some of these really are.

Push mail: Using this feature allows the service provider to push emails directly to you, without you having to poll the email provider each time to check if new mail has arrived. Currently, BlackBerry, Nokia Messaging Service and MobileMe for the iPhone are ways in which you can avail this service. Recently, a Bangalore-based firm came up with BlacMail, which basically

Samsung Wave sports the Super AMOLED screen



provides push mail services for BlackBerry me-toos.

Opt for push mail only if you are a professional and constantly need to access your mail accounts. Not a feature for leisure use. BlackBerry is the undisputed leader in this category, but recent government rulings have got people thinking. We're not worried though, because India is too big a market for BlackBerry to lose. Sure, you might lose out on some privacy, but you will still enjoy all the features. Even after the matter is settled, you will still have the same amount of privacy that you can expect from other services. Nokia is also aggressively marketing its service as a mass-based option.

Wi-Fi: This is a desirable feature, but there are some points to be noted. You're most likely only going to use this feature at home, in office, or at the occasional coffee shop or airport. It's not like we have an India-wide, or even city-wide network that you can rely on. Unless absolutely essential to you, don't pay extra for this feature when choosing a phone.

A-GPS: Another desirable feature if you are going to use a lot of apps which need you to share your location or find your way. Make sure your mobile provider supports this.

Front-facing camera: This is a completely useless feature if either you or the person you're calling are not on a 3G network that supports video calling. You could use it to set your hair, but it's not something you should pay extra for.

ebook readers: Only makes sense if the screen is large – tablet sized almost. Otherwise, it's just another feature